those interviewed were former or current soldiers or reservists. In addition, interviews were also conducted with twenty-three women and three men who were active in Kachin religious associations, multi-ethnic civil society organizations, and peace missions, as well as with external human rights groups and other non-state armed groups not associated with the KIO. The interviews took place during three field trips to the US, Myanmar, and Thailand in 2013 and 2014, each trip lasting about two to three weeks. Three translators were used for the majority of the interviews undertaken in Myanmar, two women and one man.[3] The information garnered during these relatively short research trips was studied in relation to existing literature on gender, women, and conflict, area studies on Myanmar, and previous research and work undertaken in the same area by the author.

Insecurity is important because it informs women's involvement in and relationship to political violence, which here is defined as violent acts carried out by groups and institutions with a political mandate, including non-state armed groups and governments (Davies and True 2015, p. 3). Insecurity in this context does not only relate to physical insecurity, such as the occurrence of gender-based violence, but includes broader notions of legal justice and voice, participation in decision-making structures, and socio-economic status and rights. This notion of insecurity stems from a feminist political economy approach, which understands violence as rooted in gendered inequalities (Cockburn 2004; Tickner 1992; True 2012). Such an approach is important because it allows the researcher to explore the connection between political participation, legal representation, and gendered divisions of labour as contributing to women's insecurity (True 2012, p. 30).

Insecurity informs women's participation in and support of political violence in Kachin State. This is because the outbreak and sustainment of conflict are linked to overarching structural inequalities that contribute to minority communities' exclusion from political decision-making and their relative poverty vis-à-vis dominant communities. This discrimination is even more pronounced for minority women who lack representation in the community (see Table 4.1), do not enjoy equal rights to land and household ownership (Faxon, Furlong and Sabe Phyu 2015), and report lower levels of income compared to men (MPC 2015). By paying attention to the relationship between gendered insecurity and the sustainment of conflict, I am able to analyse multiple levels of gendered socio-economic and political links that contribute to the conflict. This method allows me to